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COUTURE AT THE PALACE

Lungis, reimaged
craft and more highlights
from the ramp at the
FDCI India Men's Weekend
2026 in Jaipur **P6**

metroPLUS THE  HINDU

From a breathing ritual to a tense exchange over Epstein conspiracy theories, Marina Abramović speaks candidly on pain, and six decades of pushing her body

The Artist is *present*



Artiste Marina Abramović at the Kochi Biennale.
GAYATRI NAIR

Shonali Muthalaly
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With a thousand strangers and Marina Abramović, I breathe in. Out. In again.

The world's most famous – and most controversial – performance artist sits on stage watching us, dressed in flowing white, her Rapunzel hair falling over one shoulder, her nails painted blood red. “I always ask for the most uncomfortable chair,” she said earlier, gliding onto the stage. “It keeps me alert.”

The room is silent. "Breathe in," she says, with the calm authority of someone who has spent decades testing the limits of her own body. "Breathe out." Again and again. Twelve times in all.

My mind is racing. We are at the Kochi Muziris Biennale 2026 to listen to Marina talk about the history of performance art. The artist, now 79, has built a career on endurance – her own, and sometimes ours.

At the talk, which is based on many, many video clips, there are moments when I, along with other members of the audience beside me, cover our eyes or look away. “When you start performance, you are like a child walking in unknown territory. First I had to find what the limits are of my physical body,” says Marina. She adds, “Suffering. Mortality. Fear of pain. These are the three things people are afraid of. Every kind of art deals with this. I want to show the public, I am

the mirror. If I can do this, causing pain to get free from the pain, you can do it yourself.”

She continues, “Art has so much more to do these days, especially in the society we are living in... I don’t believe that art can change the world, but art can point to problems, and can ask the right questions.” She adds, “Being an artist is to be able to sacrifice everything. And it is a very lonely life.”

Just an hour earlier, at the press conference, a visibly nervous young performance artist, her face thick with white powder, accused Marina of being in the Epstein files. The room stilled with tension.

Marina looked at her with calm curiosity. "Are you talking about eating children?"

The young artist's hands were shaking so much she had to steady the microphone with both. "I am talking about art as a medium of control," she said. "Why do you let people control you? You are an artist, not a satanist."

With the composure of someone long accustomed to controversy, Marina replied, "You make a lot of mistakes in accusing me... It is so dangerous for me. And there is no truth in this."

She went on to explain how her Spirit Cooking dinner performance poetry was misread as satanic ritual, then woven together with Lady Gaga's visit to her show at The Museum of Modern Art (MoMA) into a conspiracy theory fuelled by rumour and misinformation.

**CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 4**

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A Space Marketing Initiative

This Valentine's Day, love steps beyond tradition, embracing selfhood, friendship, parenthood, and every honest form in between.



Siddhi Nawar

As February dawns upon the world, pop-up notifications, hoarding banners and advertisements, all seem to feature a similar pattern of exhibiting love. Valentine's Day has long been portrayed as a celebration of romantic love—red roses, candlelit dinners, matching outfits, and carefully curated gestures meant to signal devotion. But love, like life, rarely follows a template. And increasingly, Valentine's Day is being reimagined, not as a single story, but as many. For some, this Valentine arrives in the form of a long-awaited child. IVF births, once spoken about in hushed tones, are now becoming part of open, honest conversations around parenthood and choice. For parents who have walked the emotional, physical, and financial journey of assisted reproduction, Valentine's Day takes on a profoundly different meaning. It becomes a quiet celebration of resilience, science, patience, and hope. A day that honours love not as an instant spark, but as something consciously built, step by step. Retail, too, is beginning to reflect this shift, moving from couple-centric gifting to keepsakes, wellness products, nursery essentials, and self-care offerings that acknowledge these deeply personal milestones.

Me Before You

Beyond parenthood, Valentine's Day is also shedding its exclusivity. More people are choosing to celebrate solo: booking spa appointments, buying themselves flowers, indulging in a favourite meal, or simply taking the day off to rest. The idea of the "solo date" is no longer framed as a consolation, but as a choice of comfort and self-respect. It's about enjoying one's own company without apology, and recognising that feeling complete does not require external validation.

Retail trends show this clearly: personal indulgences, comfort-driven fashion, skincare, books, and home décor often outperform traditional Valentine's gifts, signalling a quiet but powerful shift in consumer mindset. Even quick e-commerce platforms offer "single" user tabs for its unattached consumers who want to avail the platform services without the suggestions on what to gift your partner. There is a growing mindfulness around this shift, one that positions self-love as a conscious, empowering choice, rather than a reluctant fallback weighed down by embarrassment or outdated notions of inadequacy. After all, charity begins at home, and choosing to see others begins with being seen by yourself without judgement and inhibitions.



Chosen Family

"But I'm a better friend than a girlfriend/ boyfriend!", is one common exasperated cry echoed among youngsters today. Needless to say, friendships have claimed their place in the Valentine's narrative since quite sometime now, prizing 'Galentine's' as the ultimate legacy. For many, chosen families and friends who have stood by through heartbreaks, career changes, health scares, and everyday chaos, are the most consistent form of love. Group dinners, shared experiences, and thoughtful, platonic gifting are becoming common ways to mark the day. It's a reminder that intimacy is not limited to romance; it thrives in laughter, shared memories, and mutual care.

At its core, this evolving Valentine's Day is less about who you are celebrating with, and more about what love means to you. It acknowledges that love can be nurturing a newborn, healing after loss, rebuilding self-worth, or simply enjoying a moment of stillness. It allows space for joy without comparison, and celebration without performance.

For retailers, this redefinition opens up a more inclusive, emotionally resonant landscape, one that moves away from rigid symbolism and towards authenticity. For individuals, it offers something even more valuable: permission. Permission to opt out of expectations, to rewrite traditions, and to honour love in ways that feel honest and personal.

This Valentine's Day, perhaps the most meaningful gesture is not fitting into a box, but gently stepping outside it. A Valentine that honours love in its truest form: fluid, fearless, and unapologetically you.

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CONTINUED FROM
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This is, after all, the artist who once stood motionless for six hours while strangers cut her skin and aimed a loaded gun at her head; who passed out inside a burning five-pointed star; who spent four days scrubbing blood-soaked cow bones at the Venice Biennale.

You expect intensity. Hers is a languid, self-confident kind. She leans back and beams. "I am here now. With you. The only thing we have in life is presence. I teach presence."

She looks around as the audience trips over itself to ask increasingly intellectual questions. "Any funny questions here?" she asks. "I love telling jokes. I didn't hear any Indian jokes."

In a biennale rich in performance art, thanks to curator, Nikhil Chopra, Marina is the crowning glory.

At the Island Warehouse close by, her massive video installation features 108 Tibetan monks and nuns chanting the heart sutra. In the muggy Kochi heat, the chants wash over you. “It took me five years. When I heard different monasteries and different traditions together, it was like a waterfall,” says Marina.

Though her two-hour talk, which drew artists, collectors and fans from across the country was a comprehensive class on performance art, Marina is most fascinating when she goes off script. The highlights of the

evening are the pieces she shows with her long time partner and collaborator, German performance artist Ulay (Frank Uwe Laysiepen).

As she plays the clip of the two of them screaming into each other's mouths, the sound goes off. "Oh my God. The sound is very important," she says, adding, "I can scream now, but I don't want to."

Then, she screams.

As the audience sits up in surprise, she chuckles, "That is enough." Another clip comes up of her and Ulay performing *Imponderabilia* at the Museum of Modern Art in Bologna. "I am sorry we are naked," she shrugs, "But this was the Seventies."

Earlier that evening, discussing her quest to come to terms with pain she had said, “Physical pain is easy to understand and feel. Emotional pain I’m not even close. Emotions are so difficult.” It makes it easier to understand why her now-viral performance at MoMA, in 2010, *The Artist Is Present* had as much impact on her as it did the audience.

"I watched 1,560 eyes. People were waiting for hours, sleeping outside the museum to see me. I



Performance is a living form of art. For it to be a living form of art it must be preserved.

MARINA ABRAMOVIC

Marina Abramovic with curator Nikhil Chopra, and gold artist patron Meha Patel.
GAYATRI NAIR

was 65 years old then, and I could never have done this when I was younger. I did not have the wisdom, or the concentration.” Ulay famously sat across her during this performance. “After three months I stood up from that chair, and I knew I was different.”

Discussing the importance of teaching, Marina says "Performance is a living form of art. For it to be a living form of art it must be preserved." Hence her Marina Abramović Institute in Greece is predictably severe. "We take your telephone, computer and watch for one week. We give you only water and tea, with a touch of honey. No food. We make you count grains of rice for hours and hours so you really understand time and concentration," she says.

"It's really important that you are fragile and strong. This is the most difficult form of art. It is all about emotion. Art has to touch you in the stomach and the heart."

It is what keeps her going, she adds. "I am turning 80 this year. I have shows booked till 2032. I am absolutely not stopping... I don't know where this energy comes from. Making art is as strong as breathing. If you stop breathing, you die. If you look at my generation, half started repeating themselves, half stopped breathing."



● **Mild Tooth of Milk at Dutch Warehouse:** Do not touch the artworks.

After seeing and obeying the sign at multiple venues, we are delighted to stumble upon Dutch Artist Afra Eisma's endearing aliens with their cuddly chubby arms and flamboyant ceramic shoes. The exhibit is a patchwork of textiles and ceramics, and beckons visitors. We lounge on the bright carpets, playing with the long limbed puppets and it is unexpectedly healing after a long day of rather intense art. Hosted by the Museum of Art & Photography (MAP) the artist invites viewers to reconsider how vulnerability, resistance, and healing can coexist. Mild tooth of mild sounds like a story from Salman Rushdie, and feels like a long hug.



● **Durga Puja at GRC Marine Yard:** While exploring Mattanchery, we follow a deep red Kolkata-inspired gully, and stumble upon Mass Art's flamboyant Durga Puja pandal-inspired installation. It features an 80 foot bamboo structure, shaped like an upturned boat. Tilting into the water, a sign declares 'Immersion invites renewal' in sunshine yellow echoing the ritual of bisarjan. Inside, I wander past sharp political caricatures set on wooden cut outs as dhak drums play. Sayantan Maitra Boka, the curator, and vice president of Mass Art explains that they partner with UNESCO to support Kolkata's Durga Puja, which he describes as the world's largest public art festival. "There are 4000 plus puja pandals, all neighbourhood commissioned. These artists in turn get help from artisans from across Bengal, who are otherwise farmers and labourers," he explains. In a dim room, a single chair bends and folds under the spotlight in an impressive display of smooth mechanics. By Bhabatosh Sutar, it is unexpectedly moving.

● **Shilpa Gupta's Listening Air at Ginger House Museum Hotel:** It is difficult to walk away. We are sitting in a darkened room, listening to voices sing 'Hum Dekhenge', the popular Urdu poem written by Faiz Ahmed Faiz. The cool room feels like balm after the blazing sun, and as our eyes adjust we notice buttery yellow lights above us moving along with the microphones. I stay here much longer than I intended to, losing track of time. The kinetic sound installation is presented with lead support from RMZ Foundation and the joint support of Vadehra Art Gallery, Chemould Prescott Road, and crowdfunding. It carries voices of solidarity from across landscapes and generations, and each time a microphone passes by, I hear a voice stand out making me feel like I am part of a moving, singing crowd.

● **Tino Sehgal's *The Kiss at Pepper House*:** I never thought of myself as a prude, but I don't know where to look. In front of me two men roll slowly on the wooden floor of Pepper House, locked in a passionate embrace. Then, they kiss. The tightly choreographed piece is daring, making audiences feel uncomfortably voyeuristic. It is also beautiful. Tino titled it after Auguste Rodin's sculpture, and modelled the choreography on well-known kisses through art history, from Constantin Brancusi to Jeff Koons. There is deliberately no information on site. Though, as with all the Kochi Biennale venues, there are helpful young volunteers on site to answer question. Also, no photographs. Which is probably a good thing. Everything has less impact when seen through your camera lens.

The art of bidding

Amarjot Kaur

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The record-breaking sale of Indian modern artworks – given in recent years – given Amrita Sher-Gil's *The Story Teller* (₹61.8 crore) in 2023 and MF Husain's *Gram Yatra* (₹118 crore) this year – puts the country's modern artists on a prominent spot in the global art market.

That should be reason enough for you to check out AstaGuru Auction House's Masters Legacy auction, which features nearly 72 (lots) masterpieces by 40 pioneering figures of the Modernist era such as Tyeb Mehta, FN Souza, SH Raza and MF Husain. "The idea behind this auction was to spotlight the golden era of Indian modernism. We wanted to bring together works that not only represent technical brilliance but also mark significant turning points in each artist's journey," says Manoj Mansukhani, CMO, AstaGuru Auction House.

He points to a rare, large-format work from Tyeb Mehta's game-changing *Diagonal* Series, when asked to highlight one of the coveted artworks at the auction. "Created at the height of a decade that redefined his artistic identity, it stands as both a collector's dream and a testament to the transformative power of this pivotal period in Indian art history," he adds.

The auction, curated over six months from October 2024 till March 2025, includes works by Indian modernists from various generations and schools of thought.

"The auction also features later-generation artists like



(Above) Tyeb Mehta's Untitled (Diagonal). SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

include MF Husain's Untitled watercolour artwork from Ghalib Book Series, estimated between ₹12 lakh and ₹15 lakh, Sital Chandra Bandyopadhyay's Untitled Oil on canvas painting dated 1930 (between ₹25 lakh and ₹35 lakh) and Archibald Herman Müller's 1930-dated oil on canvas, Surya, (between ₹15 lakh and ₹20 lakh).

Slated from April 23 at 10.30am to April 24 at 8pm, the auction will be held online.









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Abraham & Thakore

The designer duo's collection, Sartorial Sarongs, makes a literal splash, opening with two models emerging from a swimming pool. The robes they wear soon give way to lungis and mundus, an everyday garment across the country, re-imagined in a classy black and white colour palette with circular motifs, pinstripes, line prints, quirky paperclip motifs and a nod to Jaipur with Hawa Mahal featuring on the garments as well. A rolled up newspaper in the hand, is a casual accessory here on the ramp.

"Lungis and mundus can be a very elegant substitute for trouser dressing. I also like the political implication of it because it sort of questions colonial attitudes and how we have been indoctrinated to believe there is only one correct way to dress," says David Abraham.

With drawstrings, belt loops and pockets, the sarong here is for all occasions, and the collection features jazzed up versions as well. Parties and weddings this year are hopefully going to see quite a bit of the sequinned mundus in black, and a showstopping gold, crushed silk shirt and mundu set.



Vivek Karunakaran

The unmistakable beats of 'Kannodu Kanbadhellam' from *Jeans* makes the audience sit up even before Vivek Karunakaran's showcase begins. For the designer, Thangam, his latest collection is a continuation of Idam, his last collection which he considers a celebration, and a movement. "We fearlessly represented who we are and our roots. If Idam was a book, Thangam is now one of its chapters," he says.

True to its name, Thangam shimmers as models step onto the runway wearing veshtis, waistcoats, flowy pants and bandhgalas in Kanjeevarams, raw silks, tussars and organza. Not limiting the colour palette here to creams and an organza gold, Vivek also has the models don rich jewel-toned reds and pinks, subtle maroons and blacks. While flowy pants in gold match up effortlessly with a kurta and a soft blazer, panchakachams and angavastharams pair just as well with bandhgala-style open jackets, all on the ramp as strains of 'Ponmagal Vandhal' play.

Vivek also shares a personal connection to the collection – his mother's name is Thangam. "For me, it was important to move away from viewing gold simply as ornamentation and instead see it as a language of love. For generations, gold has held deep emotional significance within families."

Nikita Mhaisalkar

Nikita Mhaisalkar did not have to look further than her hometown of Sidhpur in Gujarat, with its Victorian havelis, pastel colours and migratory birds for inspiration for her newest collection, Nostalgia. "Not many people know about the town's beautiful havelis. I wanted to work around this aesthetic, the vibe, and its pastel colours," she says.

Fluid and yet sharp, well-cut garments that Nikita describes as "very French, very Victorian and very smooth", with couture embroidery inspired by the motifs and carvings from the havelis make up Nostalgia. Models strut down the runway in the evening light, with suit sets, flowy shirts and pants and feathery neckties in pastels accentuated with cameo brooches, which Nikita has an interesting sourcing story for as well.

"I met someone in Sidhpur who collects these old brooches and they were kind enough to lend it to me for the show."

Nostalgia on the runway

In its fourth edition, House of Glenfiddich presents FDCI India Men's Weekend showcased the best of contemporary menswear. We bring you the highlights



S Poorvaja

At Jaipur's Diggi palace, the high ceiling of the durbar room, the serene lawns and the calm poolside play quiet witness to all the hustle; of fashion choreographers dispensing instructions, models awaiting their turn, or lounging on the seats being readied for the evening's shows, and designers darting between the ramp and the green rooms.

For the Fashion Design Council of India (FDCI), this is the fourth year of bringing designers from across the country who are pushing boundaries and expanding the vocabulary of

menswear as a part of House of Glenfiddich presents FDCI India Men's Weekend. JJ Valaya, Ashish N Soni, Rajesh Pratap Singh, Dhruv Vaish, Antar-Agni, Sahil Aneja and more, were a part of the line up this year; a mix of celebrated designers and emerging talent.

Sunil Sethi, president, FDCI, emphasises on their commitment to present diverse contemporary menswear from 23 established and emerging designers. "I am just lucky that men's fashion is all over the country, with designers from across cities being able to showcase here, as well as different choreographers working on the shows," he says.

We bring you the highlights, and meet the designers for the low-down on what you should be adding to your closet this year.



Til by Ankur Verma

In beige, earthy greens and browns and pops of bright orange, Til by Ankur Verma's latest collection Breathe plays around with handwork and textures while keeping the brand's zero-waste, sustainable philosophy in the forefront.

A textured, drop-shoulder jacket in beige, the first garment in the showcase on the runway, is a piece so rich in texture that you wish you could examine it closer to admire the craft that has gone in. This piece, Ankur says, has been completely made of upcycled material.

"My brand is inspired by skin textures and I wanted to do something creative. From wrinkles, freckles and moles, everything takes shape here on the garment through applique work, embroidery, and more," Ankur says.

Relaxed fits, soft long jackets, hoodies, capes, shrugs and kurtas feature in the collection, versatile pieces which Ankur says can be styled separately, layered, worn over denims, or with scarves and stoles added as one wishes.



Countrymade by Sushant Abrol

'Nostalgic Utility' is how Sushant Abrol describes Foundry, his latest collection. A card describing his intriguing and inventive collection comes with Foundry Object No.01, a metal motif from a jerry can that holds fuel for military jeeps, that Sushant wants us to hold, remove and rotate.

Taking cues from workwear and adding tactile elements to make the clothes more interactive; Foundry has chore jackets, truckers, bomber jackets, and soft blazers. The denims come with hickory stripes crafted using the brand's signature French knots, embroidery on jackets that represents metal melting, and ikat used to represent a heat map of temperatures in a foundry through ochres, reds and blues. "We come from a land of rich cultural heritage and at the same time, as a brand, I feel it is my responsibility to reprogramme these crafts," says Sushant.



Son Of A Noble SNOB

Mani Shanker Singh of Son Of A Noble SNOB says he loves challenging norms. "Why should a summer palette only have certain colours?" he asks. His collection Contra, fuses military, sport and grunge, in silk, Chanderis and linens, with Japanese influences and also features hand embroidery like his previous collections.

With camouflage print kurtas, epaulettes, sharp collars and front pockets, as well as flowy pants in greens, browns, charcoal and black taking over the ramp, Mani says that his focus is on modern, hip global aesthetics, but while retaining a bit of Indianness at the same time.

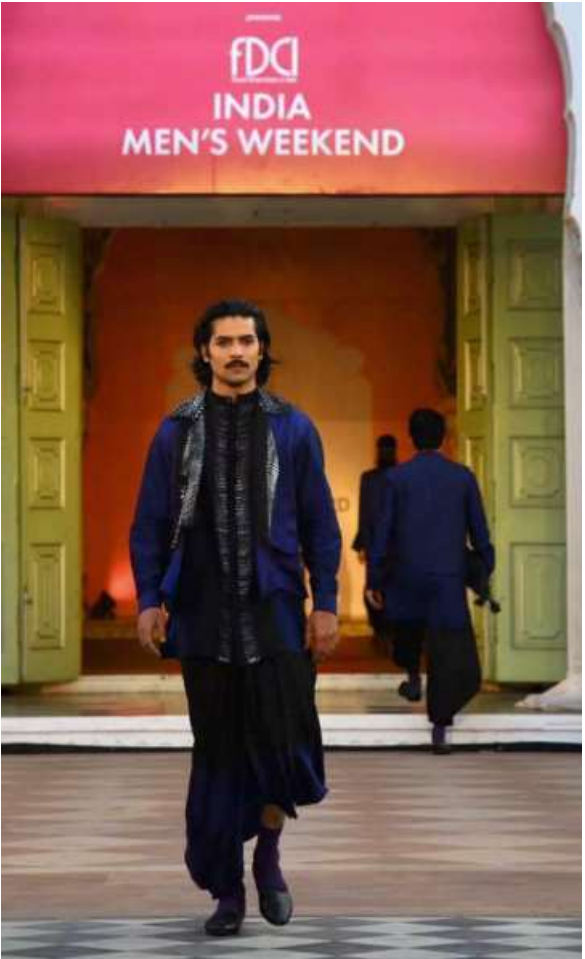


Siddhartha Tytler

The runway is illuminated in stripes of light for Siddhartha Tytler's showcase and in the spotlight is Parsi gara thread work, reimagined in his collection Miraas. "It is such a beautiful culture and tradition, with such intricate and beautiful work which you do not see very often now. We have modernised and attempted to bring it back in the open," the designer says.

Sharply tailored black-and-white kurtas and achkans in silk organza and raw silk feature intricate threadwork, elevated with mirror work and appliqué that glints under the lights as models take over the runway to a remix of Britney Spears' 'Toxic'. The show's brisk pace does not detract from the details; the striking thread work executed by a team of artisans in-house who will also be working on future collections, is exquisitely detailed.

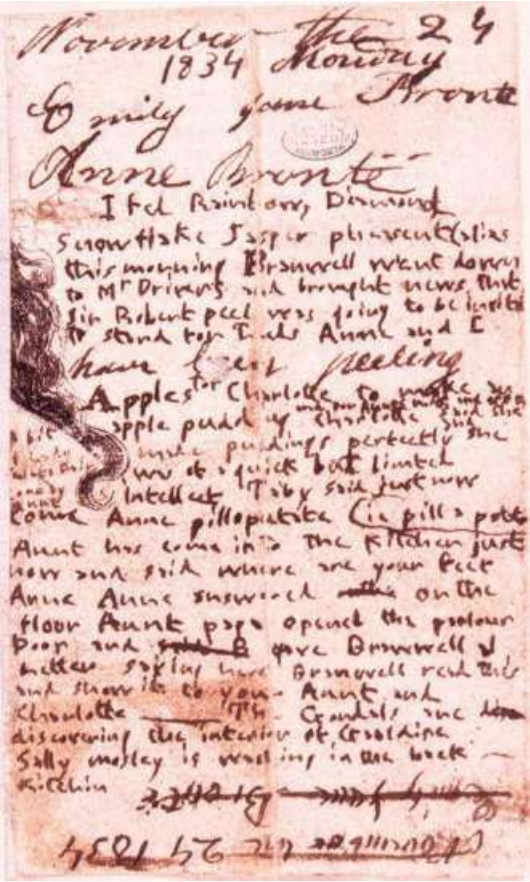
"A general rule is, if you want to get noticed, come to me," Siddhartha laughs.



Inca

"I work with craft on a very basic level. My attempt is to make it a part of your daily life and not reserve it for special occasions," says Amit Hansraj of Inca.

In flowy pants, dhotis, short kurtas, jackets and shirts, Amit's collection at the India Men's Weekend with bandhani and shibori influences popped on the runway in glossy browns, buttery ochres and bright blues. "My collection traces the journey of a dot, as it expands and shifts in shape. We start with the minute bandhani dots, and slowly branch out into bolder shibori prints; much like how you put an ink blot on a drop of water," Amit explains.



(Clockwise from far left) Brontë Parsonage Museum; a page from a diary; the Brontë workboxes; a room at the Parsonage Museum; and Margot Robbie from the film. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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An artist's sketch of Haworth Parsonage, the former residence of the celebrated Brontë sisters – Charlotte, Emily and Anne – hangs in my childhood home. Nearly 40 years old, the framed casement cloth captures the parsonage as it was in their day – a Georgian house on a desolate landscape overlooking a churchyard with moss-covered tombstones askew. The famed Yorkshire moors lie beyond – bruised by rain, mist floating eerily above the sodden grass. A landscape that the sisters saw every time they looked outside the window and one that influenced much of their writing, especially Emily's gothic *Wuthering Heights* featuring the star-crossed lovers Heathcliff and Catherine Earnshaw struggling to defy their fate on those moors. The novel is back in the news with the release of the Emerald Fennell film starring Jacob Elordi and Margot Robbie bringing a new flush of interest in the Brontë Parsonage

The house of letters

With the film adaptation of *Wuthering Heights*, based on Emily Brontë's iconic novel, now in theatres, we step inside the Brontë Parsonage Museum in Haworth, UK



Museum (BPM). Diane Fare, outreach officer, BPM, says, "Urbanisation has had little impact on the immediate surrounding of the parsonage. A photograph taken today would look very similar to a sketch drawn in the Brontës' time. Haworth itself is also relatively unchanged. The shops on the cobbled Main Street are different – there are now cafes and gift

shops rather than butchers and tailors – but the buildings look as they once did. Beyond the village, the moors are the same." The BPM is helmed by the Brontë Society, founded in 1893 to promote interest in the Brontë family and their works. Its aim was to set up a permanent home for items belonging to the Brontës, and the first museum opened in 1895 above the Yorkshire Penny Bank on Haworth Main Street. Haworth Parsonage was bought by Sir James Roberts and gifted to the non-profit in 1928 when it opened as the BPM. "The Society sought to restore it to how it would have appeared in the Brontës' time and nearly all the objects and furniture on display belonged to the family," says Diane. The BPM, open Wednesday to Monday, stands now in a well-set



Urbanisation has had little impact on the immediate surrounding of the parsonage. A photograph taken today would look very similar to a sketch drawn in the Brontës' time

DIANE FARE
Outreach officer, BPM

(particularly her best friend Ellen Nussey)," she says, adding, "Many visitors are huge fans of *Jane Eyre* and are here to see where the novel was written. Whilst we know less about Emily, her only novel *Wuthering Heights* has fascinated readers since it was published in 1847 and fans of the novel are keen to visit where the enigmatic Emily grew up and to walk the landscape that so inspired her. Since the announcement of the new *Wuthering Heights* film, sales of the novel has rocketed. Visitor numbers are in the region of 60,000-70,000 a year and the split is 80% domestic tourists, 20% from overseas."

The BPM collection is certified a Designated Collection by Arts Council England. For the London premiere of the film, Margot Robbie wore a custom replica of a 19th-Century hairwork bracelet from the BPM. Originally made from Emily and Anne's hair, the bracelet was recreated by Haworth-based Wydean Weaving to honour the literary history of the film's source material.

"Picking one object of memorabilia from the collection is too hard," says Diane. "I love the sewing boxes (called workboxes in the Brontës' time) as they were obviously heavily used by the sisters and you get a glimpse into their everyday domestic lives. In Charlotte's, there are paper patterns for cutting out clothes to be sewn, the snipped-off finger ends of kid gloves, a piece of whalebone stay, a pair of black silk cuffs, and some round, pink pillboxes with pills still inside. Anne stored pebbles collected on the beach in Scarborough."

An equal favourite is the diary papers written by Emily and Anne. "They wrote their first diary paper in November 1834 (when Emily was 16 and Anne, 14) and over the next 11 years, they filled a scrap of paper with the minutiae of a parsonage day in micro script. By the 1840s, Emily and Anne had established rules for the diary papers. They were to be written on Emily's birthday – July 30 – and on the same day they would open and read the previous ones, written four years earlier."

As a portal into how the Brontës lived and with a slew of exhibitions, talks and film screenings coming up, BPM and *Wuthering Heights* live on in collective memory, long after the moors have been covered in mist.

Maybe you will never find 'the one'

And that is ok. Polyamory taught me generosity – an ingredient in love I found scarce in monoamory

Arundhati Ghosh

"When most of us don't find even one person decent enough to love, where do you find multiple?" This is one of the common questions I get from audiences when I am sharing stories of people who lead polyamorous lives. And my answer always is, "If you stop looking for 'the one', you will find 'the many'." Riposted in jest the response does carry truth. We put too much pressure on the search for 'the one and only true love' that we have been conditioned into thinking as our sole road to happily ever after. The checklist is an impossible register of demands that includes not just our needs and desires, but also insurance against all our fears, guarantees against all possible misfortunes, and retribution for every past betrayal suffered. Since monoamorous people believe there is only a single seat in the heart where only one person can sit at a time, we have to get it absolutely right, and mistakes come at terrible costs. The brutal judgment by which we disqualify others is reciprocated in their evaluation of us too. Since each person carries their list, dating becomes an inquisition.

The harsh gaze of scrutiny leaves us with humiliation for our inadequacies and cynicism about love. The freedom from this unkindness is one of the first

delights I felt when I accepted I was polyamorous. I was just me and people could desire me, love me, and build a nurturing relationship with me, without having to

speculate if this was a sturdy enough singular investment in the joy of togetherness for a lifetime. Because I would never put an embargo on them loving other people, living other happinesses concurrently. And I could do the same for myself. Polyamory taught me generosity – an ingredient in love I often found scarce in monoamory. I discovered I was polyamorous when I was quite young. I would fall in love with a person while already being in a wonderful relationship with another.

Popular films and songs all around me warned this was wrong, immoral even – it was only possible to fall in love again when the earlier relationship had ended. But what came naturally to me was the desire to love more than one person simultaneously – being honest with all. Yet for years I struggled with labels of promiscuity as well as coping with feelings of loneliness and guilt. I am glad young people today have more courage than I did at their age. In my interviews with them, I have discovered how exhausted they are of the deceit and denial that desperately attempts to glue together worn-out, fractured relationships of our generation – consolation masquerading as happiness. They may not have the

answers yet, but they are asking the right questions, experimenting with sexual identities and attempting alternative configurations of relationships of love and friendships. Many of them have lost faith not just in the way we practise relationships but also how we conduct life – our failed kinship with Nature, our submission to greed, our inability to foster a kinder world. Polyamory is just one of the ways in which they are engaging in assembling connections, with care at the centre of the circle of love and integrity as its spirit. But it is not just young people who are contemplating polyamory today. In monoamorous relationships where the demands of exclusivity, anxieties about shortcomings, and the recurrent fear of losing love in a terrifyingly lonely world creates a fragile existence, older people with decades in their marriages are starting to question their ways of loving too. Even when they are not ready to leave the domain of monoamory, they are opening up to

conversations about insecurities, the secret toxicities suffered over the years, and what manifesting their desires could look like. While some are reimagining their relationships, others are considering renegotiating spaces for personal journeys outside of the stronghold of enshrined couplehoods. In all my imperfections, different partners love me for distinct aspects that they hold dear. The end of relationships is determined by their own dynamics, and do not succumb to a competition for affection. While I continue to feel jealous sometimes, I am not afraid of its stinging anymore. I let it breathe in me, settle its

fumes and sit down to listen to its woes. With time and the occasional assistance of partners, I manage to prevail. There is no fear of guilt if I develop feelings for people I meet. While I share this with partners with care and patience, I treasure greatly the freedom that allows me to do so. There are many joys of living as a polyamorous woman, but most of all, it has made me less afraid – of love and life.

Arundhati Ghosh is the author of the book *All Our Loves: Journeys with Polyamory in India*, published by Aleph Book Company.



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK





When Nawalgarh came into being in 1737, the Marwari community flocked to it, making it one of the most affluent places over time. Many well-known Marwari business

Boasting of the region's highest concentrations of painted havelis – close to 200, Nawalgarh is indeed one the most stunning living-art open air galleries in the world. In the mid-1900s Anandilal Podar Trust and MR Morarka-GDC



And, with small towns and their architecture now being popular destinations for Bollywood and OTT directors, the team of *Tu Meri Main Tera Main Tera Tu Meri*, starring Kartik Aryan and Ananya Pandey, also found its way to Nawalgarh in July 2025. Abid helped with the location scouting and permissions. Kartik stayed at the newly-restored Vivaana museum hotel, and even shared a sneak-peek of it on social media. Once belonging

“Architecture plays a crucial role in storytelling. Every building, with its unique elements and artefacts, has a story to tell, of its past and its people. And, having grown up in the lanes of *Purani Dilli* with a lot of nostalgia, saving the heritage of the country was always a goal,” shares Atul, while leading the tour of the

Architecture plays a crucial role in storytelling. Every building, with its unique elements and artefacts, has a story to tell, of its past and its people

ATUL KHANNA,
Governing member,
INTACH

Shekha museum on the ground floor of the one-of-its-kind museum-cum-hotel. A stone's throw away, three havelis belonging to the Jhalan family, a Goenka home, and a few more are enjoying a new lease of life. The first one of the three has been restored using the close-to-original vegetable and mineral colours. The bright blue rightly highlights the murals depicting scenes from Lord Krishna's life as it plays host to a similar video shoot. While the second one has lost just a bit of its former glory and serves as the family's vacation house, it is the third one converted into a trust school that has lost most of its frescoes and murals to modern paint.

“There is still some work left. I will restart,” says the Bhihwarra-based multi-awardee Bhairun Lal Swarnakar, an expert in miniature, pichwai, and other forms. “I started in 1995 with recreating or finishing murals on the spaces where the plaster had fallen off on the outer walls of the haveli. And, it makes me happy to see that many people are making efforts to restore more and more havelis now. Just that I wish the new generation of the painters were taught the art of making the traditional colours, and using stuff like *geru* (Indian red earth), *kajal* (natural kohl), *khadiya* (clay)... The process is time-consuming but those colours survive and keep their original tint for a longer time,” says the 75-year-old who worked tirelessly for almost a decade on the Podar haveli’s murals numbering hundreds.

Still, it seems the journey that started with the Podar and Morarka havelis is slowly and steadily finding new storytellers, and while some are basking in their all-new glory, Nawalgarh's streets are dotted with many still waiting to be rescued. Perhaps soon!



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Malayalam

Breezy
feel-good
drama



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An over-reliance on references from past hits often signals a dearth in creativity. But in *Ashakal Aayiram*, the references that fly thick and fast, all of it aimed at evoking the heydays of Jayaram in the 1990s, appear to be acts of fondness. Until the makers start overusing it to the hilt, especially towards the climax. In *Ashakal Aayiram*, directed by G Prajith, Jayaram and his son, Kalidas Jayaram, yet again get to play their real-life relationship on screen. Ajeesh Hariharan (Kalidas), neck-deep in the world of Internet reels, aspires to be an actor, while his father Hariharan (Jayaram), a medical representative, wishes that his son start thinking realistically and take up a regular job. Caught amid this father-son tussle and clash of ideas on the right way to live is Asha (Asha Sharath), the mother, who struggles in her own way to keep the family's finances afloat.

Written by Aravind Rajendran and Jude Anthany Joseph, *Ashakal Aayiram* has the structure of a typical family drama of the 90s, although it has the external appearance of a contemporary film. Ajeesh's antics to land a dream role and his father's inadvertent brush with cinema are all fodder for comedy, with some self-deprecating humour from Jayaram making it quite a breezy watch in the initial half. It is a character written with the intent to exploit Jayaram's strengths as an actor, with relatable humour and emotions. Of late, he has mostly appeared in memorable cameos in Tamil films, but it has been a long time since he made a mark in Malayalam. Here, the actor is fully in his element, apparently aware that, in the end, this is a movie meant to celebrate him, although love for cinema is the overarching theme.

But the one who almost walked away with the movie was Sharaf U Dheen, who plays Sumith Raghavan, a power-drunk star and a product of nepotism in the industry. Although the character is written with few shades, Sharaf's performance lends it much more depth. However, in the latter half, the screenplay overpowers the actor, with over-the-top lines on nepotism and contrived plot turns spoiling not just the character, but the entire movie.

Predictability of the narrative, which one ignores owing to the rather fun ride in the initial half, becomes evident as the film progresses. The manufactured conflict points also do not help the movie much. The over-dramatic sequence in the climax takes the movie down even further. At this point, a misplaced reference from the classic *Veendum Chila Veettukaryangal* lands rather jarringly, reminding us that such shortcuts can carry a movie only so far. An original and organic screenplay is any day a better bet.

Ashakal Aayiram is currently running in cinemas

Ashakal
Aayiram

Director: G Prajith

Cast: Jayaram, Kalidas Jayaram, Asha Sharath, Sharaf U Dheen, Ishaani Krishna

Storyline: A youngster who dreams of becoming a film star finds unexpected roadblocks on his way



Cute rom-com lacks emotional heft

Though written with a lot of heart and a conviction to make a simple meet-cute, debutant Madhan's film ends up as a middling rom-com that lacks inner scaffolding

Tamil

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One of the sweetest moments in life is when we cross paths with someone from a distant path in a 'small world' moment. Say you knew of a Karthik who was your school senior in Chennai; almost a decade later, a man you meet mentions a Karthik in Chennai, would you connect the two to be the same person? After all, there might be many Karthiks in Chennai. Maybe the mention of the name might trigger a memory but would you conclude or put your doubts out, interrupting a stranger talking about how they were in love with a Karthik they went to school with in Chennai?

In *With Love*, Monisha (Anaswara Rajan) recognises that her date, Sathya Seelan (Abishan Jeevinth), is, in fact, her school senior when he casually mentions that he was once in love with a girl named Anisha while studying at a school in Trichy. "Wait, is that Anisha akka?" she instantly asks, before they exchange further information.

If you think all is good and any criticism over this is nitpicking, you may not have many complaints about *With Love*, which is still a simple, sweet romance-comedy that celebrates young love. But if you are someone who looks for convincing psychological ties between actions and reactions, you might find many instances in this film quite contrived. Or have a problem even with a harmless cameo appearance by someone close to Sathya. *With Love*, directed by Madhan, is a straightforward rom-com that is aware of the emotional register it is aiming for, but lacks the substance to build to it organically.

In their meeting, Sathya and Monisha open up about their respective school-time romances. Sathya speaks about how he was in love with a classmate, Anisha (Kavya Anil), and how it all came to a head, thanks to a traitor of a friend. Monisha, an unruly backbencher, was in love with her class topper, Balaji (Sacchin

With Love

Director: Madhan

Cast: Anaswara Rajan, Abishan Jeevinth, Kavya Anil, Sacchin Nachiappan

Storyline: A young man and a woman on a date decide to go on a journey to track down their school-time crushes and express their love

Nachiappan), but circumstances never allowed her to express her feelings, and again, a betrayal seals its fate – a flashback with a beating heart, it also refreshingly shows a 'love failure' from a female perspective. These two backstories feature the strongest sequences; director Madhan understands the beauty, innocence, and pangs of school-time romance.

However, the very sentiment that propels the story forward from here, lacks the necessary emotional infrastructure. Monisha realises that they both have "an unexpressed love" in their past and decides to find their exes and express their feelings. Again, it's an impulse many hopeless romantics daydream about, but the film jumps a beat and asks us to take a leap of faith without addressing why they must dig up the past to move forward.

Given that the rest of the film follows the protagonists on this journey, it becomes of utmost importance that we know the emotional itch that needs resolution. Perhaps both of them struggle to get into anything meaningful without a closure to these chapters? We are not told.

Without any convincing psychological backing to this journey, the rest of the film rests on how they find Anisha and Balaji, and even in those regards, the film ends up with mixed results. The lack of conflicts seems quite apparent after a point, but what baffles one is how even ideas that could make way for some are resolved immediately. Ideas, though they appear good on paper, fail to translate into anything convincing on screen. When we reach the much-awaited reunion with Balaji and Anisha, you are left wondering why, when one is spelt out the other is written quite underwhelmingly.

It doesn't help the film's cause that the personal journeys of Monisha and Sathya do not flesh them out as anything more than what the larger plot wants them to be. There's an intimate moment in the second half where they get quite close after a party, something Monisha later blames on the alcohol, much to Sathya's dismay. Her casual reaction and his disbelief in her school of thought paint two extreme ideological backgrounds, but this is never addressed again.

The lapses in the story's emotional beat are evident when Sathya suffers a

heartbreak. A soup song sung by Yuvan Shankar Raja plays in the background, and while this is a great idea on paper, you end up watching these proceedings with a straight face as the screenplay hardly tries to sell anything convincing to empathise with Sathya.

It is also perplexing to see Sathya suddenly turn into someone quite immature for his age. At one moment, we see him, now an adult, get upset about the results of a game of FLAMES with Monisha – no, it is not even written as a comical moment. He appears quite hotchpotch as a character, and Abishan's enactment of an eccentric young man seems performative rather than lived-in, especially in the older portions.

If anything, it's Anaswara who ably carries the film. And yet, her character also gets underwritten. In the real world, a Monisha would have used her 1.9 million Instagram followers to get leads about Balaji and Anisha. It's nice that our Monisha wants to do it the old-school way, but her only idea is to go back to their school and see if something comes up. The parameters she seems to set to measure her potential partner aren't clear, nor are the boundaries she draws for herself. Even when Sathya does something comically extreme later, Monisha hardly addresses the concerning situation and is only bothered about where they go from there.

In an earlier scene at a cafe, a parallel between Monisha and an unidentified woman paints what it means to let someone be themselves; the other woman passive-aggressively polices Sathya for adding sugar to his coffee, but Monisha accepts him for who he is. Which is why she does not consciously ask him to stop smoking and sees in him a responsible man when he finally does. And so, these ideas only make you imagine a story about how Monisha and Sathya would deal with something that challenges this acceptance of each other. The arc surrounding Saravanan's character showed potential to help with this, but *With Love* does not wish to play the long game. It instead settles for what comes easily, a quality that harms art and love.

With Love is currently running in theatres



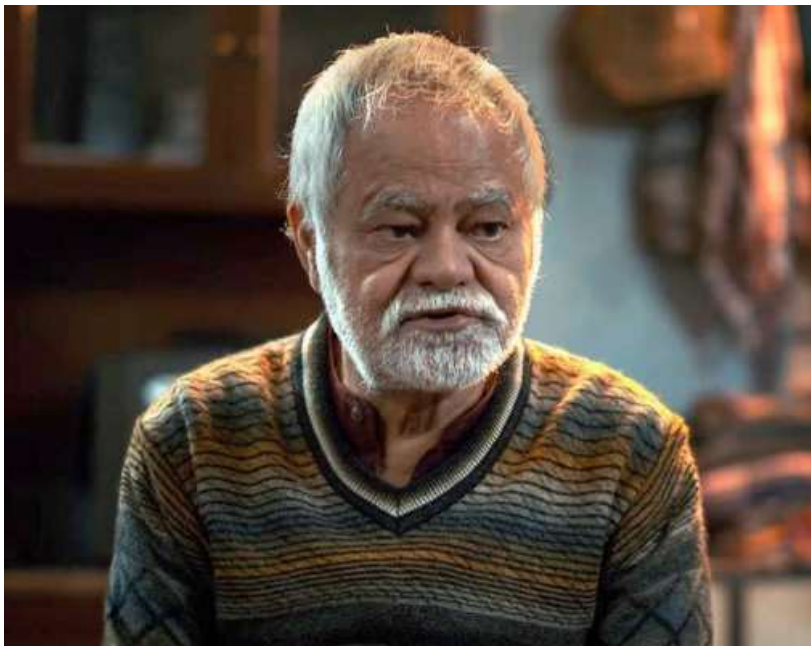
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An emotionally resonant thriller where restraint is over-stated

Hindi

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Over the years, carceral imagery has been an important creative device for shaping tales of confinement and social control. This week, Shambhunath Mishra (Sanjay Mishra), a prison guard struggling with financial burdens and personal isolation, forms an unlikely bond with Manju Singh (Neena Gupta), an inmate serving a life term for crimes she may not have committed. The intimacy amid isolation gets a jolt when one night a politically-connected predator disappears from prison, triggering an investigation. As a determined officer, Ateet Singh (Amitt K. Singh) takes charge, and elements of caste dynamics and power struggles surface, involving a strict but prejudiced superintendent (Kumud Mishra) and a perverted inmate (Akshay Dogra).



If you have watched *Vadh* and the trailer of its spiritual sequel, you can pretty much guess the who and why of the thriller in the first few minutes. It deliberately reunites the

lead actors and retains their screen names, shifting the narrative from the original's domestic thriller to a prison-set story rooted in the moral complexities and systemic flaws of

the criminal justice system. Murder with a moral, which became a rage with *Drishyam*, is the connecting link. One could see that the same thought is being reimagined from a distance, and the makers want to underline it.

As a result, the narrative structure of this slow burn doesn't hold many surprises until the efficiently concealed final twist, which leaves us amazed with a timely tweak to the karmic theory. You don't have to wait for rebirth to pay for your sin.

The film questions the idea of justice as writer-director Jaspal Singh Sandhu judiciously weaves the realities of caste, confinement, and entitlement. Sapan Narula's cinematography and Sidhant Malhotra's production design create a space you can believe in. Neena and Sanjay once again bring quiet intensity and emotional depth to the performance without making the suffering dreary. While Sanjay brings his whimsical style to Shambhu, Neena imparts grit and grace to Manju. But it is Kumud who lights up the layers in the scenario as the surname-hunting superintendent

Prakash Singh, whose righteousness is undone by his bias.

However, Sandhu spends too much time establishing the obvious good and bad, leaving the grey to go underappreciated. The modus operandi of removing evidence is

carried out with a heavy hand, and the role of call details in the investigation is conveniently forgotten. In a thriller, if the supporting characters wear their intent on their sleeves, the emotional drama leading up to that big revelation becomes laboured even in two hours.

More importantly, the uneven treatment of the second act exposes the carefully curated restraint of an unrushed thriller with middle-aged actors. A self-conscious Amit K Singh doesn't fit the film's tone. As the investigating officer, he seems to be using the opportunity to audition for a Bollywood biggie.

It is irritating to see the director allowing the character to flaunt his body in bed and strike a pose with a cigarette in a film where artistes such as Neena, Sanjay, and Kumud play on a different plane. If the idea is to bring a little more colour, it doesn't work. Eventually, it is like a well-intentioned sentence with punctuation all over the place.

Vadh 2 is currently running in theatres

The Lincoln Lawyer
(Season 4)

Creator: David E. Kelley

Starring: Manuel Garcia-Rulfo, Neve Campbell, Becki Newton, Jazz Raycole, Angus Sampson, Christopher Gorham

Storyline: Mickey Haller is in the dock for murder and the only way to clear his name is by finding out who did it



A thumping win

Streaming

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Sometimes a comfort watch is all that one wants and David E. Kelley's *The Lincoln Lawyer*, in its fourth season, offers just that. There is a mystery that does not insult one's intelligence while not being so jilebi-curly as to have one constantly going back to get the facts straight.

Based on Michael Connelly's series about a criminal defense lawyer Mickey Haller, played by Manuel Garcia-Rulfo, who operates out of his Lincoln Navigator, Season 4 is based on the sixth book in the series, *The Law of Innocence*.

Picking up where Season 3 ended, with a policeman finding the body of con artist

Maggie seems to have moved on and is dating an orthopaedic surgeon Jack (Jason O'Mara), but still worries about Mickey. Their daughter, Hayley (Krista Warner), struggles in school with her father accused of murder.

Mickey's mum, Elena (Angélica María), is convinced Mickey will be out soon in time for her wedding. Mickey's mentor Legal (Elliott Gould), is worried for him but also sure he will be acquitted.

The deputy district attorney prosecuting Mickey, Dana Berg (Constance Zimmer), is universally feared and has a multitude of nicknames including "Death Row Dana". She has an axe to grind against Mickey. The presiding judge Lionel Stone (Scott Lawrence) is no-nonsense but fair.

Some ghosts from Mickey's past resurface, including the crooked real estate developer Alex Gazarian (Michael Goorjian); chef Lisa Trammell (Lana Parrilla); and FBI agent Felix Vasquez (Hemky Madera). The FBI in the form

of Vasquez and his partner, Dawn Ruth (Sasha Alexander) seem to be involved in the case.

Bamba (Marcus Henderson), whom Mickey pays to keep him safe in jail, asks Mickey for a job on the outside. Mickey hiring Bamba to drive him (not in his Lincoln, which is locked up as evidence) seems more trouble than it is worth.

The tangled web of renewable energy, the mob and scamming the government, has to be unravelled before arriving at the truth of Sam's murder.

The 10 episodes move by smoothly in a jolly mix of courtroom drama, action and breathtaking twists and turns, including an ankle bracelet running out of charge among other things. The cast and the City of Angels are easy on the eye and the promise of another season coming up is just what the doctor ordered.

The Lincoln Lawyer currently streams on Netflix

Snippets



Paul Thomas Anderson wins DGA Award for *One Battle After Another*

Paul Thomas Anderson claimed the top honor at the Directors Guild of America Awards on Saturday night, winning Outstanding Directorial Achievement in Theatrical Feature Film for *One Battle After Another*.

The win is a significant milestone in Anderson's career. Long regarded as one of contemporary cinema's most influential filmmakers, Anderson has now secured the industry's most reliable predictor of the Academy Award for Best Director. Twenty of the last 23 DGA winners have gone on to win the Oscar in the same category.

The evening underscored the DGA's emphasis on solidarity within the industry, with Guild president Christopher Nolan addressing concerns about employment.



Heated Rivalry to release in India

Are you all ready to go to *the cottage*? *Heated Rivalry*, the internationally acclaimed television series, is all set to scorch hearts in India soon. The hit Canadian romance series, created by Jacob Tierney, will premiere on Lionsgate Play in India on February 20.

A series that captures raw emotion and an authentic portrayal of queerness and ambition, *Heated Rivalry* follows the story of Ice Hockey rivals Shane Hollander and Ilya Rozanov, who get into a steamy secret relationship.

Based on the *Game Changer* book series by Rachel Reid, the show stars Hudson Williams as the golden-boy Shane, while Connor Storrie plays the magnetic Ilya, together creating chemistry that simmers and explodes on screen.



A glorious gory path to truth

Striking production and sound design, audacious action, mean monsters and standout performances mark the sophomore sprawl

English

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After that mind-blowing (literally) opener in episode 1, *Fallout* settles into an easy rhythm. Based on Bethesda's eponymous video game, *Fallout* is set 200 years after a nuclear holocaust following the Great War of 2077.

While some of the population lives in vaults (unaware they are sociological experiments), the surface is a wasteland with people scratching out an existence in a savage battle for survival.

Season 1 ended with an uneasy alliance between Lucy (Ella Purnell), a vault dweller who has come to the surface looking for her father, Hank (Kyle MacLachlan), and The Ghoul (Walton Goggins), a Hollywood star in the before times.

The Ghoul, mutated by radiation poisoning and kept from going feral with chemicals, knows a lot about Vault-Tec, the evil corporation, and politicians who

Fallout Season 2

Creators: Graham Wagner, Geneva Robertson-Dworet

Cast: Ella Purnell, Aaron Moten, Kyle MacLachlan, Moisés Arias, Xelia Mendes-Jones, Walton Goggins, Frances Turner, Kumail Nanjiani, Macaulay Culkin

Episodes: 8

Storyline: Lucy's search for her father and The Ghoul's for his family, continues with friends and foes helping and hindering them along the way

are responsible for the state of the world. He is looking for his wife Barbara (Frances Turner), a senior Vault-Tec executive and their daughter, Janey (Teagan Meredith).

Lucy has an ally in Maximus (Aaron Moten) of the Brotherhood of Steel, a group that eschews pre-war technology. Maximus grows increasingly disillusioned with the infighting among different branches of the Brotherhood. Matters reach a head with the appearance of Paladin Xander Harkness (Kumail Nanjiani) an uninvited envoy from the Commonwealth Brotherhood of Steel.

There is plenty happening in the vaults too, with water running out; Lucy's friend Steph (Annabel O'Hagan) hiding a secret; and Lucy's brother Norm (Moisés Arias) escaping from Brain-on-a-Roomba (giggle), also known as Vault-Tec senior junior vice president Bud Askins (Michael Esper), and awakening all the cryogenically frozen Vault-Tec employees.

Steph insists Lucy's cousin Chet (Dave Register) look after her baby and Councillor Reg (Rodrigo Luzzi) sets up an inbreeding support group with unlimited snacks.

The many threads might seem to be all over the place, but strong performances from the ensemble cast anchor the story.

While Purnell, Moten, MacLachlan, and Goggins are excellent, inhabiting their characters like a second skin, Justin Theroux as the oily CEO of RobCo Industries, Robert House, Nanjiani and Macaulay Culkin as Lacerta Legate, from Caesar's Legion, a group modelled on ancient Rome, create unforgettable characters.

Ramin Djawadi's score is bright and jolly even as mayhem is unleashed on screen. Produced by Jonathan Nolan and Lisa Joy (*Westworld*), *Fallout* is eminently watchable from its themed titles to explosive action and game Easter Eggs.

There are delightfully horrid monsters from cockroaches and scorpions as big as leopards to the dreadful Death Claw. The writing is as sharp as it is funny including Legate's line "good is not a meaningful vector in history" and The Ghoul's ironic "never underestimate the power of brand recognition."

The post-credit scene in the finale, where all is made clear and obscured, points to season 3, which has already been greenlit.

Fallout is currently streaming on Amazon Prime Video